

Making `std::unique_ptr` constexpr

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1 Introduction

`std::unique_ptr` is currently not `constexpr` friendly. With the loosening of requirements on `constexpr` in [P0784R10] and the ability to use `new` and `delete` in a `constexpr`-context, we should also provide a `constexpr std::unique_ptr`. Without it, users have to fall back to the pre-C++11 area and manually manage the memory. A non-`constexpr unique_ptr` also reduces the use-cases where users can benefit from the dual nature of `constexpr`, having the same code that runs at compile- and run-time.

There is no reason that the code below does not compile and users are forced into manually managing the memory.

```
1 constexpr auto fun()  
2 {  
3     auto p = std::make_unique<int>(4);  
4 }
```

```

5     return *p;
6 }
7
8 int main ()
9 {
10    constexpr auto i = fun();
11
12    static_assert(4 == i);
13 }

```

Listing 1.1: unique_ptr test case 1: make_unique

2 Implementation

This proposal was implemented in a fork of libc++ from the author [GHUImpl]. The only issue that was encountered was that the comparisons `<`, `<=`, `>`, `>=` lead to an error with Clang:

note: comparison has unspecified value

which makes the code not a constant expression. Below is a simplified version of the code triggering the error (online: <https://godbolt.org/z/cqadjr>):

```

1 #include <functional>
2
3 constexpr bool f()
4 {
5     int* a = new int{4};
6     int* b = new int{5};
7     return std::less<int*>()(a, b);
8 }
9
10 int main()
11 {
12     constexpr bool b = f();
13
14     return b == true;
15 }

```

Listing 2.1: Simplified issue in unique_ptr when using comparisons

2.1 What about relational operators?

The paper leaves the non-`nullptr` versions untouched. Except for the `nullptr`-versions the result for such a comparison is unspecified (see [expr.rel] p4.3). This seems like a general decision for LEWG how to treat such functions.

2.2 What about `make_unique_for_overwrite`?

During the presentation to LEWG in May 2021, the question was raised whether `make_unique_for_overwrite` is possible to implement, and those should stay in the paper. Since the adoption of [P1331R2] in

C++20 default initialization is allowed in `constexpr`-functions. Implementing `make_unique_for_overwrite` therefore is no issue.

The following code demonstrates this using Clang (<https://godbolt.org/z/arebKdPvh>):

```

1  template<typename T>
2  class unique_ptr {
3  public:
4      constexpr unique_ptr(T* ptr)
5          : _data{ptr}
6          {}
7
8      constexpr ~unique_ptr() { delete _data; }
9      constexpr T* get() { return _data; }
10
11 private:
12     T* _data;
13 };
14
15 template<typename _Tp>
16 constexpr unique_ptr<_Tp> make_unique_for_overwrite()
17 {
18     return unique_ptr<_Tp>(new _Tp);
19 }
20
21 constexpr bool Fun()
22 {
23     auto x = make_unique_for_overwrite<int>();
24
25     *x.get() = 0; // without this init the next line causes an error
26     (*x.get())++;
27
28     return true;
29 }
30
31 int main() { constexpr auto v = Fun(); }
```

Listing 2.2: Minimal implementation of `make_unique_for_overwrite`

3 What about other smart pointers

The implementation in [GHUImpl] also covers a partial `shared_ptr` and `make_shared`. The approach was to get the following code to compile and run:

```

1  #include <memory>
2  #include <iostream>
3
4  constexpr auto fun() {
5      std::shared_ptr<int> p{new int{4}};
6
7      return *p;
8  }
9
10 auto test() {
```

```

11  std::shared_ptr<int> p{new int{4}};
12
13  return p;
14 }
15
16 int main() {
17     constexpr auto i = fun();
18
19     static_assert(i == 4);
20
21     auto s = test();
22
23     std::cout << *s << '\n';
24 }

```

Listing 3.1: shared_ptr test case 2: using make_shared.

The attempt was brute-force, compile it and add `constexpr` to all the methods Clang complained about not being usable in a constant expression. For `unique_ptr` that approach worked well. For `shared_ptr` it stopped working when the following allocation happened (<https://git.io/Jkxnm#L3702>):

```

1  template<class _Tp>
2  template<class _Yp>
3  _LIBCPP_CONSTEXPR_AFTER_CXX20 shared_ptr<_Tp>::shared_ptr(_Yp* __p,
4                      typename enable_if<__compatible_with<_Yp, element_type>::/
                        value, __nat>::type>
5      : __ptr__(__p)
6  {
7      unique_ptr<_Yp> __hold(__p);
8      typedef typename __shared_ptr_default_allocator<_Yp>::type _AllocT;
9      typedef __shared_ptr_pointer<_Yp*, __shared_ptr_default_delete<_Tp, _Yp>, _AllocT >/
        _CntrlBlk;
10     __cntrl_ = new _CntrlBlk(__p, __shared_ptr_default_delete<_Tp, _Yp>(), _AllocT());
11     __hold.release();
12     __enable_weak_this(__p, __p);
13 }

```

Listing 3.2: Object _CntrlBlk cannot be used in a constant expression

The error was:

```

note: non-literal type '_CntrlBlk' (aka '__shared_ptr_pointer<int *, /
__shared_ptr_default_delete<int, int>, allocator<int>>') cannot be used in a constant /
expression

```

The cause of the error was from the atomics a `shared_ptr` needs internally in the control block. The approach was to wrap all uses of atomics with `std::is_constant_evaluated` (see <https://git.io/Jkxnm#L3136> for an example). In one case, a wrapper was needed (see <https://git.io/JkAFz#L3257>). `__release_weak` has the implementation in `memory.cpp` presumably to hide some atomic includes. The newly introduced wrapper uses `std::is_constant_evaluated` to switch between `constexpr` and run-time.

The next issue was the following:

```

memory:1581:13: note: 'std::allocator<...>::deallocate' used to delete pointer to object /
allocated with 'new'

```

```

        ::operator delete(__p);
        ^
memory:3333:9: note: in call to '&__a->deallocate(&{*new _CntrlBlk#1}, 1)'
    __a.deallocate(_PTraits::pointer_to(*this), 1);

```

We are looking at a variation of the first test-case 3.1, this time the `shared_ptr` is created and a pre-allocated object is passed to the constructor:

```

1  #include <memory>
2  #include <iostream>
3
4  constexpr auto fun() {
5      std::shared_ptr<int> p{new int{4}};
6
7      return *p;
8  }
9
10 auto test() {
11     std::shared_ptr<int> p{new int{4}};
12
13     return p;
14 }
15
16 int main() {
17     constexpr auto i = fun();
18
19     static_assert(i == 4);
20
21     auto s = test();
22
23     std::cout << *s << '\n';
24 }

```

Listing 3.3: `shared_ptr` test case 2.

The implementation of `libc++` uses `allocator::deallocate` to free the memory in `__on_zero_shared_weak` (see <https://git.io/Jkxnm#L3330>), which is a specialization for the case when a `shared_ptr` can have a custom deleter, like when it is created directly by its constructor with pre-allocated memory. However, in that case, the memory was previously allocated with `new` by a user. A simplified example of the situation is the following (<https://godbolt.org/z/oPG8Ea>):

```

1  #include <memory>
2
3  constexpr auto fun()
4  {
5      int* i = new int{4};
6
7      std::allocator<int> a{};
8      a.deallocate(i, 1);
9
10     return 0;
11 }
12
13 int main()

```

```

14 {
15     constexpr auto f = fun();
16 }

```

Listing 3.4: Reduced example of a allocation with new and deallocation with `std::allocator`

Interestingly GCC has no issue with that code, while Clang rejects it. The wording in [?] [allocator.members] p6 says that `deallocate` must be called with memory previously allocated with `allocate`. The implementation of Clang seems to be the correct one. It further seems that the constant evaluation path did reveal UB in libc++.

Coming back to making `shared_ptr` constexpr. The change in libc++ was using `delete` in the case described instead of referring to `allocator`.

After sprinkling some more constexpr in the minimal examples 3.1 and 3.3 did successfully compile and run.

3.1 What about the missing atomics

With the implementation as provided, a `constexpr shared_ptr` does not use atomics to maintain the internal count. Is this an issue? The author thinks no. Currently, there is no support for concurrency in a constant expression. Thus the absence of atomics is not observable to users. Should the language allow concurrency at some point at compile-time, the now missing atomic support will likely be available, and we can build a `constexpr shared_ptr` with atomics.

3.2 Further steps

A dedicated paper is planned to propose a `constexpr shared_ptr`.

4 Polls

4.1 LEWG 2021 May 26 (virtual)

Make `unique_ptr` constexpr as outlined in P2273 (not including comparisons for the purpose of this poll).

Strongly Favor	Weakly Favor	Neutral	Weakly Against	Strongly Against
8	10	2	0	0

Attendance: 25

Outcome: Consensus in favor (no dissent)

Make the ordered comparison operators taking two `unique_ptr`s constexpr.

Strongly Favor	Weakly Favor	Neutral	Weakly Against	Strongly Against
0	3	13	0	0

Attendance: 25

Outcome: Strongly don't care (no consensus either way)

Explore making shared_ptr and make_shared constexpr.

Strongly Favor	Weakly Favor	Neutral	Weakly Against	Strongly Against
1	7	4	3	0

Attendance: 24

Outcome: Weak consensus

WA: Not worth the time.

5 Proposed wording

This wording is base on the working draft [N4892].

Direction to the editor: please apply `constexpr` to the corresponding declarations in the detailed specification.

Change in [memory.syn] 20.11.1:

```
// 20.11.1, class template unique_ptr
template<class T, class... Args>
    constexpr unique_ptr<T> make_unique(Args&&... args);
template<class T>
    constexpr unique_ptr<T> make_unique(size_t n);
template<class T, class... Args>
    unspecified make_unique(Args&&...) = delete;

template<class T>
    constexpr unique_ptr<T> make_unique_for_overwrite();
template<class T>
    constexpr unique_ptr<T> make_unique_for_overwrite(size_t n);
template<class T, class... Args>
    unspecified make_unique_for_overwrite(Args&&...) = delete;

template<class T, class D>
    constexpr void swap(unique_ptr<T, D>& x, unique_ptr<T, D>& y) noexcept;

template<class T, class D>
    constexpr bool operator==(const unique_ptr<T, D>& x, nullptr_t) noexcept;
template<class T, class D>
    constexpr bool operator<(const unique_ptr<T, D>& x, nullptr_t);
template<class T, class D>
    constexpr bool operator<(nullptr_t, const unique_ptr<T, D>& y);
template<class T, class D>
    constexpr bool operator>(const unique_ptr<T, D>& x, nullptr_t);
template<class T, class D>
```

```

    constexpr bool operator>(nullptr_t, const unique_ptr<T, D>& y);
template<class T, class D>
    constexpr bool operator<=(const unique_ptr<T, D>& x, nullptr_t);
template<class T, class D>
    constexpr bool operator<=(nullptr_t, const unique_ptr<T, D>& y);
template<class T, class D>
    constexpr bool operator>=(const unique_ptr<T, D>& x, nullptr_t);
template<class T, class D>
    constexpr bool operator>=(nullptr_t, const unique_ptr<T, D>& y);
template<class T, class D>
    requires three_way_comparable<typename unique_ptr<T, D>::pointer>
    compare_three_way_result_t<typename unique_ptr<T, D>::pointer>
    constexpr operator<=>(const unique_ptr<T, D>& x, nullptr_t);

```

Change in [unique.ptr.dltr.dflt] 20.11.1.1.2:

```

namespace std {
    template<class T> struct default_delete {
        constexpr default_delete() noexcept = default;
        template<class U> constexpr default_delete(const default_delete<U>&) noexcept;
        constexpr void operator()(T*) const;
    };
}

```

Change in [unique.ptr.dltr.dflt1] 20.11.1.1.3:

```

namespace std {
    template<class T> struct default_delete<T[]> {
        constexpr default_delete() noexcept = default;
        template<class U> constexpr default_delete(const default_delete<U[]>&) noexcept;
        template<class U> constexpr void operator()(U* ptr) const;
    };
}

```

Change in [unique.ptr.single.general] 20.11.1.3.1:

```

// 20.11.1.3.2, constructors
constexpr unique_ptr() noexcept;
constexpr explicit unique_ptr(pointer p) noexcept;
constexpr unique_ptr(pointer p, see below d1) noexcept;
constexpr unique_ptr(pointer p, see below d2) noexcept;
constexpr unique_ptr(unique_ptr&& u) noexcept;
constexpr unique_ptr(nullptr_t) noexcept;
template<class U, class E>
    constexpr unique_ptr(unique_ptr<U, E>&& u) noexcept;

// 20.11.1.3.3, destructor
constexpr ~unique_ptr();

// 20.11.1.3.4, assignment
constexpr unique_ptr& operator=(unique_ptr&& u) noexcept;
template<class U, class E>
    constexpr unique_ptr& operator=(unique_ptr<U, E>&& u) noexcept;
constexpr unique_ptr& operator=(nullptr_t) noexcept;

// 20.11.1.3.5, observers
constexpr add_lvalue_reference_t<T> operator*() const;

```



```
constexpr pointer operator->() const noexcept;
constexpr pointer get() const noexcept;
constexpr deleter_type& get_deleter() noexcept;
constexpr const deleter_type& get_deleter() const noexcept;
constexpr explicit operator bool() const noexcept;
```

```
// 20.11.1.3.6, modifiers
```

```
constexpr pointer release() noexcept;
constexpr void reset(pointer p = pointer()) noexcept;
constexpr void swap(unique_ptr& u) noexcept;
```

Change in [unique.ptr.runtime.general] 20.11.1.4.1:

```
// 20.11.1.4.2, constructors
```

```
constexpr unique_ptr() noexcept;
template<class U> constexpr explicit unique_ptr(U p) noexcept;
template<class U> constexpr unique_ptr(U p, see below d) noexcept;
template<class U> constexpr unique_ptr(U p, see below d) noexcept;
constexpr unique_ptr(unique_ptr&& u) noexcept;
template<class U, class E>
    constexpr unique_ptr(unique_ptr<U, E>&& u) noexcept;
constexpr unique_ptr(nullptr_t) noexcept;
```

```
// destructor
```

```
constexpr ~unique_ptr();
```

```
// assignment
```

```
constexpr unique_ptr& operator=(unique_ptr&& u) noexcept;
template<class U, class E>
    constexpr unique_ptr& operator=(unique_ptr<U, E>&& u) noexcept;
constexpr unique_ptr& operator=(nullptr_t) noexcept;
```

```
// 20.11.1.4.4, observers
```

```
constexpr T& operator[](size_t i) const;
constexpr pointer get() const noexcept;
constexpr deleter_type& get_deleter() noexcept;
constexpr const deleter_type& get_deleter() const noexcept;
constexpr explicit operator bool() const noexcept;
```

```
// 20.11.1.4.5, modifiers
```

```
constexpr pointer release() noexcept;
template<class U> constexpr void reset(U p) noexcept;
constexpr void reset(nullptr_t = nullptr) noexcept;
constexpr void swap(unique_ptr& u) noexcept;
```

Modify [version.syn]

```
#define __cpp_lib_constexpr_memory 201811L202104 // also in <memory>
```

6 Acknowledgements

Thanks to Ville Voutilainen for encouraging me to also look into [shared_ptr](#) and reviewing a draft of this paper. Thanks to Barry Revzin and Tim Song for their feedback on R0. Thanks to Tim Song for reviewing the wording.

7 Revision History

Version	Date	Changes
0	2020-11-27	Initial draft
1	2021-04-06	• No new feature test macros, bump existing one. • Make <code>default_deleter</code>, <code>swap</code> and comparisons against <code>nullptr</code> constexpr as well. • Add instructor to editor regarding corresponding declarations.
2	2021-07-05	• Added poll results. • Clarified on <code>make_unique_for_overwrite</code>. • Rebased wording on [N4892].

Bibliography

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<https://github.com/andreasfertig/llvm-project/tree/af-constexprUniquePtr>